V

PART FIVE ·

The 39th Trial as Story

The beats in order, the women who leave and when, the story the Broadcast tells, and a planner for every chapter.

i · How to use this part	352
ii · Before the Crownward	353
iii · Genesis, the Temple's phase	355
iv · Exodus, the Crown's phase	356
v · Revelation, Endurance	357
vi · The Declaration and after	358
vii · Who's still there	359
viii · The Broadcast's story	360
ix · The religious line	361
x · Threads into book two	362
xi · The chapter planner	363

TR CR TL FR 19–25

CONTENT

Two deaths and violence in Endurance. Content notes sit at the top of the pages that carry them.

MARGINALIA

The Trial as story

Volume One treats the Covenant Trials as an institution, how they work in any year. This part is the 39th as a plot. It prints the beats your files already fix, in order, and leaves a chapter column beside each one, so the outline and the files stay in the same place.

The three phases already line up with the novel's three movements. The Temple's phase asks who are you, and the novel calls it Genesis. The Crown's phase asks how smart are you, and it's Exodus. Endurance asks what you're willing to endure, and it's Revelation (TR). Every beat sits under one of the three, and the Trial's own scripture-shaped names are the Empire's choice, which the novel is free to turn. After the beats come four tools: a tracker of who's still in the Crownward at each phase, the Broadcast's story set against what happened, a map of where each character stands on the book's religious line, and a chapter planner with room for fifty-two chapters.

✣ *See also:* Vol. I, the three phases, 569.

Before the Crownward

TKC: TL · TR · DR3 · MEN · DOM

BEAT	WHAT THE FILES GIVE	CH.
2101 · the Designation	Highest score in Aurem's history, the flag filed that day. She tells Celeste only when asked, and Celeste goes back to the stove (**TL**).	
Bell	Won't sponsor her. Asks about her father and her mother's Binding, and prays a door shut (**DR3**).	
The clause and the fee	Six months of paperwork at the kitchen table while Celeste keeps her hands busy. Ten dollars, a red card (**TL, DR3**).	
The Regional Assessment	Three days in Aurelia, the board posted at seven in the morning. First (**TL, DR3**).	
The Governor-Prelate	Selects her second. His first choice withdraws the night before departure, and it isn't a family health emergency (**TR**).	
The household	Solomon prays over her. Zion promises to look after Celeste (**TL**).	
The last night	Celeste holds her face and says remember what I told you about the real name of this city (**TL**).	

THE SCENE BEFORE CHAPTER ONE THAT THE READER NEVER SEES, AND WHAT IT CHANGES

TKC: TR · CR · DOM

Arrival week

BEAT	WHAT THE FILES GIVE	CH.
The staggered arrivals	Seven days, one Covenant Daughter a day, each released as its own day of content, each with two Appointed Officers and her House Mother (**TR**)	
The Sovereign Bridge	She crosses it and looks up at her own face on the screens, exactly where she planned to be (**CR**)	
Day five	She looks at the city first, carries her own bag, and walks the Boulevard at her own pace. The Broadcast uses forty-seven seconds (**TR**, **DOM**).	
In the Palace	Judah watches the footage and sets down whatever he was holding. Three times before he knows why he can't stop (**CR**).	
House Aurem	Hannah, Mirielle, Gavin and Abigail (**TL**)	

WHAT EACH OF THE OTHER ELEVEN DOES ON HER ARRIVAL DAY THAT THE BROADCAST KEEPS

GENESIS · WEEKS ONE TO FOUR

TKC: TR · CR · TL · FR 23–24

VOL. I · 570

CONTENT NOTE A death.

BEAT	WHAT THE FILES GIVE	CH.
The Settling	The most intense assessment of the four months, presented as a grace period. Everything feeds the score (TR).	
Sera decides	The first day of the Settling, that afternoon (TR)	
The Prelate decides	A conclusion about Eden in the first week, shared with no one (CR)	
The Tea Party	Corinne and Calla's tension begins (TR)	
The Doctrinal Assessment	Six hours in silence in the Sanctum. Eden's score is the highest in the Trial's history (TR).	
The Theological Interview	Two hours, three extra pages, and an officer who can't tell aligned from clear-eyed (TR)	
The Public Testimony	No handler. Lyris, her hands, and Judah, six minutes in. Fourth to first (TR).	
Petra	Dies before Phase Two. "A sudden medical event." The Trial loses nothing (TR, FR 23–24).	

WHEN IN THE FOUR WEEKS PETRA GOES INTO THE EAST WING, AND WHEN SHE DIES

TKC: TR · TL

VOL. I · 570

CONFLICT

Exodus · weeks five to ten

BEAT	WHAT THE FILES GIVE	CH.
The Dominion Forum	Eden moves the room in twenty minutes. Sera shifts to her side. Four words in the hallway. Delia votes with Eden (**TR**, **TL**).	
The Civic Debates	Governance, theology, social policy, topics an hour before. Abigail in amber for theology (**TL**). Eden argues for the room and the editor (**TR**).	
Before Social Policy	Nadia withdraws, no reason given (**TR**). Maren and Vivienne are eliminated, by one version of the file (**TR**).	
The Social Policy debate	Judah moderates. Delia votes with Eden again (**TL**).	
The Anointed Evening	Four hours, eleven minutes with Lyris, three things. Judah watches and decides something (**TR**).	
The Pairing Introduction	Thirty minutes. Officials out, a wire check, "I know" (**TR**).	
The trap	Corinne sets it, and Sera walks into it (**TR**).	
The trade	Ruth goes home so Sera stays. Ruth doesn't know why (**TR**).	

WHAT JUDAH DECIDES AT THE ANOINTED EVENING

Revelation · three days in Mountain

CONTENT NOTE A killing, a woman left unconscious, and injuries.

BEAT	WHAT THE FILES GIVE	CH.
Deployment	Filmed. After that, no schedule, no handlers, no cameras. Coordinates to reach across three days. Mountain terrain, for the first time since the 31st Trial, unexplained (TR).	
Day 1	Vivienne's ankle fails on a slope, and she's extracted at the first checkpoint. Delphine takes a head injury and is extracted (TR).	
Day 2	Corinne pushes Calla into the river. One person sees (TR).	
Day 3	Eden and Delphine knock Maren unconscious and leave her (TR).	
The final checkpoint	Eden, Zara, Sera and Delia. Corinne completes Endurance (TR).	
The narrative turns	The Broadcast's story about Eden shifts in Phase Three. In Celeste's kitchen, something in Leah goes very still and then very loud (MEN).	

CONFLICT Delphine on Day 1 and Day 3. Five finishers for four places (TR). See Part III.

WHAT THE BROADCAST RECONSTRUCTS OF THE THREE DAYS, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT

TKC: TR · CR · FR 19–25

VOL. I · 573 · 525

The Declaration and after

BEAT	WHAT THE FILES GIVE	CH.
The rankings	Third and fourth become Ladies in Waiting. Delia is one (TR).	
The Declaration	Live on Sovereign Boulevard. He can choose any of the twelve, deviation is expensive, refusal is abstention (FR 20–22). He chooses Eden (TR).	
The eleven	Married down the ladder as designated. The two who died, their status back to their families (FR 19, 24).	
Covenant Week	A Palace residence, the score retired for The Chosen (CR)	
The Anointing	Day six, the Prelate, oil, unfilmed (CR)	
The Binding Night	The Emperor's private charge to his son (CR)	
The Grand Binding	Two hundred feet alone down the Sanctum, vows twice as long as his, the gold cord (CR)	
The Procession and the Supper	Sovereign Boulevard, then five guests at most (CR)	

OPEN QUESTION The Crownward file calls the Declaration the moment Eden planned for and "the moment that will be taken from her" (CR). What's taken, if she wins?

THE FIVE GUESTS AT THE PRIVATE SUPPER

WHO'S STILL THERE

TKC: TR

CONFLICT

Read across a row to follow one woman, or down a column to see the room at that point.

	PHASE ONE	PHASE TWO	ENDURANCE	THE END
Eden	in	in	finishes	Anointed Wife
Delphine	in	in	out, Day 1	married down
Maren	in	out, or in	left, Day 3	married down
Corinne	in	in	finishes	married down
Calla	in	in	dies, Day 2	
Nadia	in	withdraws		married down
Ruth	in	sent home		married down
Delia	in	in	finishes	Lady in Waiting
Vivienne	in	out, or in	out, Day 1	married down
Petra	dies			
Zara	in	in	finishes	advances
Sera	in	nearly removed	finishes	advances

The files have Zara and Sera advance to "final consideration," and "married down" follows FR 19 for everyone not chosen. **INFERENCE** Two who advance and lose are married down too, unless one is the second Lady in Waiting.

TKC: TR · CR

VOL. I · 572 · 478

The story the Broadcast tells

Every Trial gets an antagonist narrative, assigned to whichever candidate most threatens a comfortable outcome. When a woman's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it the Eve problem. The narrative implies and never accuses, and it moves the score without changing a single formal assessment (TR).

PHASE	WHAT THE BROADCAST SAYS	WHAT HAPPENED
Arrival	Forty-seven seconds of Eden (TR)	
Genesis		
Exodus	Eden's debates, deprioritized (TR)	
Revelation	The narrative shifts (MEN)	
Calla and Petra		
The Declaration		

THE BROADCAST DIRECTOR WHO SIGNS THE NARRATIVE-PRIORITY DECISIONS, AND WHAT HE SAYS IN THE ROOM

Where everyone stands

VOL. I · 518

ALL DOSSIERS

The novel's religious line runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something it doesn't control (Vol. I, 518). Place each character on it at the start of the book and at the end. Movement in either direction is a plot.

CHARACTER	AT THE START	AT THE END	WHAT MOVED THEM
Eden			
Celeste			
Leah			
Ruth			
Nadia			
Zara			
Judah			
Lyris			
Hannah			
The Prelate			
Bell			

INTERPRETATION The faith spreads in each dossier are the evidence. A character who quotes what the Temple reads and hasn't heard what it skips is usually on the usable side.

TKC: FR 18 · FR 29 · FR 34 · MEN · TR · CR

Threads into book two

MIRIAM'S FATHER	He knows there are children but not how many or their names, and learned about Eden the day the Trial went public. He's the only person watching who understands what he's looking at (**FR 18**).
THE 2085 COHORT	Twelve women who know each other from being measured against each other, scattered through their Dominions. A network that doesn't wake before book two (**FR 34**).
SOLOMON	The teacher notes Eden doesn't know about, and the moment she understands winning was a beginning (**MEN**).
NAOMI	Entered or taken out, depending on what Eden's win proves (**FR 29**).
DELIA	What she does as a Lady in Waiting (**TR**).
SERA	A flag updated after the Trial, privately (**TR**).
THE REGISTRY	Whoever controls what it says controls something more basic than law. Eden will understand this before most people do (**CR**).
THE DISSENT	Wherever Dorian keeps it (**FR 42**).

THE THREAD I'M ADDING

The chapter planner

YOURS

PLANNER

One row per chapter. Write the phase as Genesis, Exodus or Revelation, and put the scripture the scene sits on in its column, even if no one in the scene says it.

CH.	PHASE	WHERE	WHOSE SCENE	THE BEAT	SCRIPTURE UNDER IT	DONE
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						

YOURS

PLANNER

The chapter planner, continued

CH.	PHASE	WHERE	WHOSE SCENE	THE BEAT	SCRIPTURE UNDER IT	DONE
14						
15						
16						
17						
18						
19						
20						
21						
22						
23						
24						
25						
26						

The chapter planner, continued

CH.	PHASE	WHERE	WHOSE SCENE	THE BEAT	SCRIPTURE UNDER IT	DONE
27						
28						
29						
30						
31						
32						
33						
34						
35						
36						
37						
38						
39						

YOURS

PLANNER

The chapter planner, continued

CH.	PHASE	WHERE	WHOSE SCENE	THE BEAT	SCRIPTURE UNDER IT	DONE
40						
41						
42						
43						
44						
45						
46						
47						
48						
49						
50						
51						
52						

Working Questions for the Trial

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

BACK MATTER LOG

1 · WHO ARRANGED THE WITHDRAWAL OF THE GOVERNOR-PRELATE'S FIRST CHOICE, AND WHEN DOES EDEN FIND OUT?

2 · WHO SEES CORINNE AT THE RIVER, AND WHAT DOES THAT PERSON DO WITH IT?

3 · WHY DOES NADIA WITHDRAW?

4 · WHAT IS CORINNE'S TRAP FOR SERA?

5 · WHAT DOES JUDAH DO WITH THE RECOMMENDATION, AND WHAT DOES IT COST HIM?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

5 · WHAT DOES JUDAH DO WITH THE RECOMMENDATION, AND WHAT DOES IT COST HIM?

BACK MATTER

Register, Conflicts and Log

What's fixed, every ruling in brief, where the files disagree about these people, what's still yours to decide, and the record of what you decide next.

The canon register	370
The Final Rulings, in brief	372
Superseded and in conflict	375
Open questions, gathered	377
The discovery log	379

DECIDED

FINAL RULINGS

RULING

VOL. I · 580

What's fixed

Everything here is canon until you overrule it. The Final Rulings outrank every source file, and your own rulings outrank the rest. Volume One's register is on page 580 of that volume.

ITEM	RULING	WHERE IT LANDS
ZION'S AGE	**DECIDED** Eighteen at chapter one, born 2085 (Ruling, October 23, 2026). **SUPERSEDED** Nineteen (**MEN**).	Zion, the household tree
SOLOMON'S AGE	**DECIDED** Sixteen, born 2088. **SUPERSEDED** Thirteen (**TL**).	Solomon
LEAH	**DECIDED** Twenty, younger than Eden, and she sat for an assessment	Leah
THOMAS	Left voluntarily in 2084 (**FR 3**)	Thomas, Miriam
MIRIAM	Reassigned after Thomas left (**FR 0**). Celeste has no proof she's alive (**FR 16**).	Miriam, Celeste
SOLOMON'S FATHER	The man Miriam was reassigned to (**FR 0**)	Solomon
THE PRELATE	**POSSIBLE** Working name Aurelia. Never Huldah or Naomi (**FR 33**).	The Prelate
CREST	Dorian's uncle (**FR 35**)	Dorian, the tree
DORIAN	Fifty-nine (**Ruling**)	Dorian
CALLA	Surname Merritt (**Ruling**)	Calla
LYRIS	Never called anything else (**WR 32**)	Lyris
THE ELEVEN	Married down the elite ladder. Nobody goes home unassigned (**FR 19**).	Part III
CHILDREN	Classified by household registration (**FR 32**)	Naomi, the Osei children

Decided after this printing

LOG NO.	DATE	WHAT I DECIDED	REPLACES	DOSSIERS AFFECTED

FINAL RULINGS 0–15

The Final Rulings, in brief

The full text is in the Final Rulings register. These are the rulings as the dossiers use them.

FR	RULING
0	Solomon's father is the man Miriam was reassigned to after Thomas left. Solomon stays sixteen and kept the Osei name. Zion was conceived before Thomas left and born after, with no memory of him.
1	Commonwife is a registration status, not a description.
2	Thomas's children are Eden, Leah and Zion. Celeste's reclassification absorbs all four.
3	Thomas left voluntarily in 2084. The record that he relocated was accurate.
4	Eden entered Celeste's household in 2085, after Thomas had gone. The others stayed with Miriam until 2090.
5	Two waves: Eden alone in 2085, the younger three together in 2090.
6	Miriam left all four with Celeste and went alone. Whether each child forgives her isn't decided.
7	They were never in her father's household. She found him after they were placed.
8	She may have meant to come back. Celeste heard the instability under the promise.
9	She was protecting them from the reassigned household and the search. Whether also from herself stays open.
10	The reclassification made the household expensive to unmake.
11	Leah watched her pack. Eden was told to take Zion outside. Solomon was two.
12	"She's coming back," for about a year, then nothing.
13	Eden remembers a task. Zion remembers the yard and has never said so.
14	Leah remembers a decision, so she's the angriest and the one who defends Miriam.
15	Being unreachable wasn't selective.

The Final Rulings, continued

FR	RULING
16	One letter in 2094, intercepted. Celeste never knew of it and has no proof Miriam survived. Who intercepted it stays open.
17	Miriam's father was Crownward-resident and close to the Vanes, and surviving an unregistered ceremony wasn't an oversight.
18	She returns with conviction, expecting not to be believed, because the arrangement that kept her away ended. Her father knows there are children, and learned of Eden when the Trial went public.
19	The other eleven are married down the elite ladder. Nobody goes home unassigned.
20	The heir may choose any of the twelve. "Without deviation" is a record, not a rule.
21	Winning means being the choice that costs the Crown nothing.
22	Refusal is abstention, and the recommendation stands.
23	No downgrade once announced, except for a dynastic emergency. A candidate's death doesn't count.
24	A candidate who dies has her status restored to her family, with no compensation and no punishment.
25	Rejected candidates are married down, and the rejection follows them in the room.
26	One Covenant Daughter per Dominion. Hannah's twelve girls are her career.
27	Eligibility isn't entry. Naomi may self-nominate.
28	Elite husbands are chosen by committee and ranked by standing. A man may decline the assignment, and two have.
29	If Eden wins, Hannah enters Naomi. If Eden dies or is rejected, Hannah gets her out.
30	Naomi doesn't know about 2085.
31	Naomi's father is on the elite ladder below Crown level, living, outside the household.

FINAL RULINGS 32–44

The Final Rulings, continued

FR	RULING
32	Children are classified by household registration, not parentage or appearance.
33	Hannah's daughter keeps the name Naomi. The Prelate is renamed, and "Nomi" is rejected as too close.
34	The 2085 cohort know each other, went home with no placements, and don't activate before book two.
35	Dorian's removed parent was Elias's elder child. Crest is Dorian's uncle.
36	The removal was in 2061, when Dorian was a child.
37	Crest was aware and didn't act.
38	Dorian was spared because a child's claim can be supervised.
39	Succession by survivorship. The 2085 Trial was cancelled for the transition, and 2104 is the 39th.
40	Crest preserved the documents.
41	Azrael found them during a Crown advisory access period.
42	Dorian removed them the week Azrael was declared dead.
43	A document Azrael had read and returned was one Dorian controlled.
44	Dorian has known the ledger names Elias since 2061.

The Final Rulings register closes with the Prelate's working name, Aurelia, marked POSSIBLE.

Where the files disagree about these people

SUPERSEDED · AGES	Solomon at thirteen (TL). Zion at nineteen (MEN). Dorian at sixty-one (CR). Leah as the older sister (TL).
SUPERSEDED · THOMAS	"Thomas Osei disappears," and Celeste "always believed otherwise" (TL). He left voluntarily (FR 3).
SUPERSEDED · CELESTE	An earlier round had her knowing Miriam was alive. She has no proof (FR 16).
SUPERSEDED · NAMES	Calla Hart (TL), now Merritt. Prelate Naomi (TR, CR) and Prelate Huldah (AM), now renamed (FR 33). Crest as Dorian's father (CR).
CONFLICT · MIRIAM'S BIRTH	Born "in Aurelia" in 2062, and Celeste settles there in 2071 (TL).
CONFLICT · ZION'S SPEAKING	"Two years ago," with Eden away watching the Trials (MEN). At eighteen it was 2103, and she was home.
CONFLICT · LEAH'S REVIEW	"Living under Temple review" (TL), and no formal note filed yet (MEN).
CONFLICT · CALLA'S MOTHER	A Covenant Daughter in the 32nd Trial (TL), which was 2097, when Calla was fourteen.
CONFLICT · DORIAN IN 2061	"A child" (FR 36), and about sixteen by his birth year.
CONFLICT · THE LEDGER	Azrael doesn't put it back, and it vanishes from the east wing archive in 2100 (TL).

WHERE THE FILES DISAGREE, CONTINUED

CONFLICT · MAREN	Eliminated before the Social Policy debate, and knocked unconscious on Endurance Day 3 (TR).
CONFLICT · VIVIENNE	Eliminated before the Social Policy debate, and extracted on Endurance Day 1 (TR).
CONFLICT · DELPHINE	Extracted on Day 1, and with Eden on Day 3 (TR).
CONFLICT · THE FINAL CHECKPOINT	"One of the four women," and five who finish (TR).
CONFLICT · SERA'S DECISION	On the Settling's first day, and forty minutes into the Forum (TR).
CONFLICT · THE DECLARATION	Eden wins (TR), and it's "the moment that will be taken from her" (CR).

A CONFLICT I'VE FOUND SINCE THIS PRINTING

What you still have to decide

OPEN QUESTION

Each one sits on its dossier page too. They're gathered here so you can work through them in one sitting.

QUESTION	DOSSIER	DECIDED?
Where Celeste was born, and who taught her scripture	Celeste	
The house name Celeste gave Eden	Eden	
Eden's Designation track	Eden	
Whether Miriam returns in this book or book two	Miriam	
Who intercepted the 2094 letter	Miriam	
How reassignment worked, and why Solomon kept the Osei name	Miriam, Solomon	
What Home Instruction is	Leah	
Hannah's surname, age, and the order of 2085, Vowed and Binding	Hannah	
What Judah knows about Hannah	Hannah, Judah	
Naomi's age, and where she studies	Naomi	
Who Serenity is	Abigail	
Whether Maribel and Corinne Vale are related	Officials, Corinne	

OPEN QUESTION

What you still have to decide, continued

QUESTION	DOSSIER	DECIDED?
How Petra got into the east wing, and who the boy next door is	Petra, Azrael	
Why Nadia withdrew	Nadia	
Corinne's trap for Sera	Corinne, Sera	
The second Lady in Waiting	Part III	
Whether Lyris was a Covenant Daughter, and why her parents had Imperial Mourning	Lyris	
Whether Dorian knows Azrael is alive, and who the other two are	Dorian, Azrael	
Who arranged Azrael's "medical event"	Azrael	
What the Prelate concludes about Eden	The Prelate	
The Prelate's real name, and whether "Aurelia" can share the city's name	The Prelate	
What's "taken" from Eden at the Declaration	Part V	

The discovery log

Anything you find about these people starts as POSSIBLE. It moves to DECIDED only when you've decided it belongs in the manuscript, given it a number here, and noted which dossiers it changes.

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	DOSSIERS IT CHANGES

YOURS

LOG

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	DOSSIERS IT CHANGES

The discovery log, continued

NO.	DATE	WHAT I FOUND	STATUS	DOSSIERS IT CHANGES

NOTES

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